



NEW WESTMINSTER



CHILD CARE STRATEGY

October 2016

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Executive Summary



The City has made significant progress in addressing the child care needs of parents and children in New Westminster. Much of this progress can be attributed to City Council's decision to be a municipal leader in the area of child care. It can also be attributed to the development of needs assessment studies to better target interventions and the allocation of appropriate municipal resources to facilitate new child care spaces.

To maintain the momentum, the City has developed its third Child Care Strategy (2016) and the second in seven years. This strategy builds on the previous award winning strategy and provides an overall vision, policy framework and three-year action plan.

Despite the significant progress made to date (i.e., over 600 new child care spaces with another 180

child care spaces in the planning and development process), the City still faces several challenges related to specific care types (e.g., infant/toddler) and neighbourhoods (e.g., Queensborough). This strategy will create a facilitative environment for child care while targeting resources at specific needs and gaps.

The strategy recognizes the important role to be played by the senior levels of government as municipalities have limited resources and taxation powers. Their involvement will be critical to realizing a comprehensive child care system in New Westminster – i.e., one that includes the provision of quality programs that are accessible and affordable.





Section 1: Introduction

The 2016 Child Care Strategy provides an overall vision, policy framework and three-year action plan in support of a comprehensive child care system in New Westminster – i.e., one that includes the provision of quality programs that are accessible and affordable.

The strategy defines the City's role, which has evolved over time to include direct provision and support for child care. It also recognizes that the

City has limited resources and taxation powers and that the senior levels of government need to take a more active role to meet the growing need and demand for child care, as they are primarily responsible for its funding and provision.

The strategy reflects City Council's belief that quality, accessible and affordable child care is necessary to create a complete and healthy community and a prosperous economy.



“Child care is now a necessity for many families. Without it, they cannot afford housing, which forces many to move to the suburbs. Child care needs to be an economic development priority. We need to keep existing and attract new families if we want to have a strong economy.”

*Child Care Operator Survey Respondent,
2014*

Section 2: Background



In 2008, City Council voiced its desire to be a municipal leader in the area of child care. To this end, the City conducted a Child Care Needs Assessment (2008) and Strategy (2009). The City also designated a staff person to oversee strategy implementation.

Since the development of the assessment, the City has realized over 600 new child care spaces with another 180 child care spaces in the planning and development process. It was also the recipient of several major awards, including the 2012 Provincial Child Care Award of Excellence and 2013 Planning Institute of British Columbia Award of Excellence for Planning Practice. The City is now considered a municipal leader in the area of child care.

The City, with the assistance of the Kids New West Child Care Action Team, completed a new

Child Care Needs Assessment (2015). Based on this assessment, the City and the Action Team developed a new Child Care Strategy (2016). This strategy is intended to continue to position the City as a municipal leader in the area of child care.

“The situation has definitely improved but not for all care types. There are many desperate parents looking for infant/toddler care. It is difficult to turn them away as there are few other options. There needs to be more funding and incentives to develop this care type.”

Child Care Operator Survey Respondent, 2014





Section 3: Child Care Needs Assessment

The City has now prepared three Child Care Needs Assessments – i.e., 1995, 2008 and 2015. As part of the recommended actions in this Child Care Strategy (2016), the City is committed to conducting an assessment every five to seven years, thus avoiding situations where there is a 13 year gap, which can be detrimental for child care planning and development.

The 2015 Child Care Needs Assessment, similar to the 2008 Child Care Needs Assessment, defines what is meant by child care and describes the different types; details its importance from both a social and economic perspective; discusses how it is provided and funded and outlines the City's current role; examines the existing child care situation, including supply and demand factors; and identifies and analyzes a number of related issues.

The 2015 Child Care Needs Assessment was informed by the Kids New West Child Care Action

Team and is based on the input and feedback of 396 parents, which represented the child care needs of 595 children, and 41 child care operators, which represented 66.6% of all child care spaces. The two surveys were augmented by additional information, including a focus group with parents of children with extra support needs and focus groups and surveys with low-income families and new immigrants.

The 2015 Child Care Needs Assessment provides the context for and informs the development of this strategy. For example, the finding that there are no group infant/toddler and only limited school age care spaces in Queensborough informed the recommended action to explore all mechanisms, including developing civic child care facilities, using community amenity contributions, accessing senior government grants and working with developers, to realize such spaces in this neighbourhood.

"I'm glad that we are asking parents for their opinions. Now if we could just get the decision-makers to listen, we may make some headway on this all important issue."

*Child Care Parent Survey
Respondent, 2014*



Section 4: Importance of Child Care



Quality, accessible and affordable child care provides significant benefits for children, families and municipalities.

Children

Quality child care positively influences child development. Children have opportunities to learn how to get along with others and to learn new skills in a safe and nurturing setting. These positive childhood experiences have been found to enhance school readiness and success.

Parents

Quality child care positively influences parenting decisions and contributes to child wellbeing. Parents have opportunities to learn about different developmental and parenting issues and together with qualified child care staff, they can address concerns that may arise during a child's development in order that interventions can be incorporated.

Municipalities

Quality child care is an important consideration in reducing differences in developmental vulnerability across neighbourhoods, when taking into account parental education and style, family income and neighbourhood socio-economic characteristics.

Quality child care is also an important consideration in attracting and retaining women within the labour force; attracting families with younger children to the city; and attracting and retaining businesses, as it positively impacts worker productivity.

“Child care is just too important to leave it up to the market. For those that can’t afford it, their children are often in unlicensed settings, which may be placing them at risk. Let’s recognize the many benefits (of child care) and fund it accordingly. “

*Child Care Parent Survey
Respondent, 2014*





Section 5: Role of the Senior Levels of Government

Over the past decade, some municipalities have moved beyond their legislated responsibility to oversee land use and building safety related to child care to that of facilitator, negotiator and funder in creating new child care spaces.

While this Child Care Strategy (2016) sees an important role for the City to play, including as an active partner and, in some cases, funder and direct service provider, it recognizes that the senior levels of government must significantly increase their support of and funding for child care if true gains are to be made. The BC Early Years Strategy, the BC Early Childhood Educator Bursary and the Provincial Office of the Early Years, are important steps and signal a willingness on behalf of the Province to work with municipalities to enhance the quality of and access to child care and early years programming. The new Federal government, as part of its 2016 Federal Budget, is proposing to invest \$500 million in 2017-18 to support the establishment of a National Framework on Early Learning and Care.

To this end, this strategy includes recommended actions related to collaboration, partnership and advocacy. Most importantly, there is a need to address affordability issues, as more and more families, despite the increase in the availability

of child care, are unable to access child care due to the cost, especially when combined with high housing costs.



“There has to be more funding to make child care less costly for families. Once you get into school-age care it is more reasonable but infant, toddler and pre-school age care is so expensive that many people I know can’t afford to work. This leaves them out of the job market and re-entry is difficult.”

*Child Care Parent Survey
Respondent, 2014*

Section 6: Recommended Child Care Policy



The 2009 Child Care Strategy included a policy statement, which based on the 2015 Child Care Needs Assessment is still very much applicable today. More specifically, it emphasized the need for a comprehensive child care system that includes the provision of quality programs that are accessible and affordable.

There has been significant progress made with regard to the quality of child care, as there are now a number of purpose-built child care facilities in New Westminster, including one owned by the City and two owned by the School District. Additionally, as a result of the City of New Westminster Child Care Grant Program, \$187,796 has been allocated to non-profit child care operators to address building deficiencies and purchase needed equipment and furnishings to meet provincial licensing requirements.

There has also been significant progress made with regard to improving access to child care, particularly related to availability. In fact, there were 493 child care spaces created between 2008 and 2014 in New Westminster, which represented an increase of 41.2%. An additional 123 child care spaces became operational by June 2015, with another 180 child care spaces currently in the planning and development process.

There has been far less progress made with regard to affordability. Based on the 2008 parent survey, 15.0% of respondents reported that cost of child care

was a challenge in finding a placement and based on the 2014 parent survey, 30.6% of respondents with a placement and 49.4% of respondents looking for a placement reported that cost was a challenge. Affordability is the area where the City has the least influence. As such, there is an important role for the senior levels of government to play in adequately funding child care and subsidizing access to it.

The recommended child care policy statement is as follows:

The City of New Westminster recognizes that child care is an essential community-based service and that it makes a valuable contribution to the social and economic development of the community. It is also an investment in the future, as high quality child care is associated with improved child outcomes, including school readiness and success.

The City of New Westminster is committed to being a leader and an active partner with the senior levels of government, the School District, businesses, child care providers, faith organizations, parents and the community in developing and maintaining a comprehensive child care system. A comprehensive child care system is one that includes the provision of quality programs that are accessible and affordable.

Quality

A quality child care system is one which supports the child's emotional, intellectual, physical and social development and assists and complements the family in its child-rearing role. Research and experience indicate that the predictors of quality programming include: the existence of and compliance with licensing standards; the provision of specific staff training in child development and early childhood education; the effective administration of programs; the involvement of parents in the care option of their choice; and the provision of sufficient operating funds and program resources to support care that is developmentally and individually appropriate.

Accessible

An accessible child care system is one in which there is appropriate and adequate capacity for all families and children requiring care. This means an integrated continuum of services for children from birth to 12 years of age in developmentally appropriate programs for infants, toddlers, preschoolers

and elementary school-aged children; the planning, coordination and delivery of child care services at the neighbourhood level; the provision of culturally and linguistically appropriate services; and the development of physically accessible facilities that promote the full inclusion of all children.

Affordable

An affordable child care system is one which provides access to quality care for all families regardless of their income. It is also one which is adequately funded and resourced by the senior levels of government.

“All levels of government need to get together and develop a plan. Many parents can't afford child care and many operators can't afford to reduce fees. The real losers are those children who miss out on quality care and learning. Child care is an investment in the future.”

*Child Care Operator Survey
Respondent, 2014*



Section 7: Recommended Actions



The recommended actions are based on a review of the 2009 Child Care Strategy and the findings of the 2015 Child Care Needs Assessment. The recommended actions were also informed by the Kids New West Child Care Action Team and the City of New Westminster Community and Social Issues Committee.

advocacy, will be implemented by the City over a three-year period starting in November 2016, with a report back as to progress made in each of the following three Octobers. It is recognized that the senior levels of governments have a significant role to play, as many of the issues related to availability and affordability are beyond the influence and scope of the City.

The recommended actions, with the exception of those related to collaboration, partnership and

Proposed Actions	2016-17	2017-18	2018-19	Ongoing
Policy and Planning				
That the City develop a new Child Care Needs Assessment every five to seven years. Such assessments are essential in planning for child care, including identifying needs and gaps. To date, assessments have been developed in 1995, 2008 and 2015.				x
That the City continue to implement the Child and Youth Friendly Community Strategy (2016), which is informing the development of neighbourhoods which meet the needs of children, youth and families. This strategy, which is a corporate strategic policy priority, includes a domain on caring.	x	x	x	
That the City designate child care as a standard community need similar to park land and that it be considered in municipal policy, planning and land use decisions, including the review of larger developments and master planned communities.				x
That the City establish targets for the number and type of child care spaces by sub-area and for larger developments and master planned communities. ¹				
That the City consider building or incorporating space for child care facilities as part of the development of new municipal facilities or major renovations to existing ones.				x
That the City expand the use of development variance permits to vary the required off-street parking requirements to facilitate the provision of child care outdoor space. Currently, the policy is limited to Downtown New Westminster.		x		

¹The City has received information related to the Vancouver Child Care Calculator. This calculator is based on a number of inputs, including the female labour force participation rate; the amount of revenue producing commercial space or commercial and industrial employment; and the number of family (2+ bedroom) and non-family (0-1 bedroom) units.

Proposed Actions	2016-17	2017-18	2018-19	Ongoing
Direct Support				
That the City continue to fund the Child Care Grant Program and that it consult successful and unsuccessful applicants to identify possible program enhancements.	x			x
That the City, in collaboration with Fraser Health, explore the development of a child care as part of the IDEA Centre (Economic Health Care Cluster) in Sapperton. This child care would meet the needs of health care workers, including those working shifts, and the community.	x	x	x	
That the City explore all mechanisms, including developing civic child care facilities, using community amenity contributions, accessing senior government grants and working with developers to realize group infant/toddler and school age care spaces in Queensborough. ²	x	x		
That the City examine different mechanisms to grow the Child Care Reserve Fund. Currently, this fund is dependent on density-bonusing revenues, which have only yielded limited funding to date (i.e., less than \$100,000).		x		
That the City support child care facilities in applying for senior government funding, accessing statistical information, exploring new locations, facilitating partnerships, etc.				x
Information Dissemination				
That the City, in collaboration with the YMCA Child Care Resource and Referral and the Welcoming and Inclusive New Westminster Local Immigration Partnership Council, include information related to child care in the update of the Your New West Newcomers' Guide (2012).	x			
That the City develop a Good Neighbour document to minimize conflicts and negative externalities related to child care operations, particularly in residential neighbourhoods.		x		
That the City update its Step-by-Step Guide to Setting-Up a Licensed Group Child Care Facility (2010), which provides information on the different types of child care, the Zoning and Building Code requirements, the municipal approvals process and relevant contact information.		x		
That the City, possibly in conjunction with Fraser Health Community Care Facilities Licensing, host a child care information session for those interested in operating a family daycare home or in-home multi-age care operation in Queensborough.	x			
That the City prepare information for faith organizations. This information would document the benefits to the organization and community, clarify licensing requirements, discuss the importance of lease agreements and terms of use, and include tips to avoid potential conflict situations.		x		

²Currently, there are no group infant/toddler and only limited school age care spaces in this neighbourhood.

Proposed Actions	2016-17	2017-18	2018-19	Ongoing
That the City prepare information for developers and realtors. This information would document needs, identify opportunities, discuss facility requirements, and provide links to resource materials. This could include a role for the City's Economic Development Department.		x		
Collaboration and Partnership				
That the City continue to participate on the Public Partners Child Development Committee and Kids New West Committee, including any action teams related to child care and child development.				x
That the City, through its representation on the Public Partners, continue to identify development, funding and partnership opportunities in support of the creation of East and West End Child Development Hubs.				x
That the City and School District review the Child Care Protocol (2009), which was endorsed by both parties, and that they identify additional opportunities for collaboration within their collective control.		x		
Advocacy				
That the City continue to advocate for a publicly funded child care system similar to that of the public education system.				x
That the City work with the Ministry of Children and Family Development and the Office of the Early Years to enhance access to the Child Care Subsidy, including for median or moderate income families.	x			
That the City work with the Ministry of Health to explore strategies with regard to meeting outdoor play space requirements. It is extremely difficult in built-up and dense areas, such as New Westminster, to meet these requirements.	x	x		

³New Westminster City Council has endorsed the Community Plan for a Public System of Integrated Early Care and Learning (2011). This plan calls for affordable parent fees, an early years centre network and a new home for child care in the BC Ministry of Education.



Section 8: Implementation, Monitoring and Reporting

The City, with the assistance of the Kids New West Child Care Action Team, will prepare an annual update report to City Council. The report will provide information as to the current child care situation in New Westminster [e.g., number of child care spaces created since the development of the Child Care Needs Assessment (2015), new opportunities or challenges related to child care, etc.]. The report will also provide an update on the progress made in implementing the strategy. More specifically, it will identify the actions implemented in a given year (i.e., November to October) and the status of action implementation (i.e., fully, partially or not at all). If partially or not at all, it will state the reason(s) (e.g., inability to involve key partners, lack of resources, etc.). Based on the report, the strategy could evolve and change to address new issues or respond to unforeseen circumstances.

“More reasonably priced fees. Combine child care and housing and it is almost impossible to make ends meet. There is a need to subsidize all parents.”

*Child Care Parent Survey
Respondent, 2014*



